Fat Boy vs the Cheerleaders

By Geoff Herbach

CRIME REPORTER: **(Pg v)** Shortly before midnight on June 15th Gabriel Johnson, a sixteen-year-old from Minnekota, MN was apprehended outside Cub Foods. Johnson possessed $17.75 in small bills and change, which he confirmed had been removed from the vending machine at Minnekota Lake High School. Police suggested the alleged robbery was related to a larger conflict involving assault, vandalism, and defamation of character that has come to be known as the Spunk River War.

GABE: **(Pg 1)** *(speaking to his attorney; very nervous)* Ripping off the pop machine last night wasn't meant to be funny. It was my duty to all the geeks, burners and oddballs in this school because that machine sucks. Why are you laughing? I robbed the machine all my myself. It was eighteen dollars, but I lost a quarter when Officer McCoy roughed me up. Look at my chin! I have scrapes all over my stomach and knees too.

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(Pg 2) Stupid Pop machine. Stupid pop.

(Pg 7) Hey. Shouldn't we be talking about how . . . how you're going to keep me from going to jail or something? I'm a little nervous about my crime. *(listens for a moment)* The whole story, huh? Okay. You asked for it . . .

INTRODUCTION

(sound effect from the opening of Law and Order, Special Victims Unit; "chuk, chuk")

In the juvenile justice system soda-based crimes are considered especially heinous. At Minnekota Lake High School, the purchasers of these sodas are members of a rhythmically challenged squad known as the Marching Band. Their leader? Gabriel Johnson (aka Chunk). This is his story. ("chuk, chuk")

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GABE: **(Pg 4-5)** Here's the scoop, sir: Purchasers a pop at the Minnekota Lake High School are fat a**es, trailer park kids, addicted gamers and chicks who eat cigarettes for breakfast. Dozens of these kids went back for seconds. Some for thirds (me for instance). Two cheerleaders purchased from the machine, but they both bought diet. That diet stuff will kill you but

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not make you fat.

JUSTIN: *(to Gabe)* You drink a lot of pop, Chunk! I'm just sayin'. *(indicating Gabe's size)*

GABE: Yeah. Really. I drank a ton of Code Red Mountain Dew every day – 4, 5 bottles – and the only pants that fit me were stretchy pants – elastic waistband, sir. *(demonstrates the stretchiness of his waistband)* Kids call me fat, butter ball, Eight-Butt Johnson. **(Pg 39)** Justin was the first person to call me Chunk. He said I looked like this fat kid in an 80s movie. **(Pg 5)** I knew pop was part of my issue. But see, I also thought it was part of my success. All the vending machine money went to fund the band! I love band! I love band so much . . . I'm a trombone player. That's one awesome instrument, right? *(mimes playing the trombone and marching with pizzazz)* I was winning by buying all that pop!

(Pg 13) Okay. So Wednesday morning -- totally evil surprise. Parched, ready for my first Dew of the day, I strolled into the cafeteria and discovered that all pops had been jacked from a buck fifty to $2.25! No longer did I have the proper coinage for three Code Reds. I

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only had enough for 2. I couldn't make it through a day on 2 Code Reds! ***Oh, no, no –***

(Pg 17-18) After school Justin and I walked into the principal's office. Without my minimum 3 Code Reds, I was totally wiped and a bit confused and my muscles felt like bags of sand. Mr. Deevers wasn't happy to see us. Maybe because he's a central figure in a scheme to defraud students out of their hard-earned dollars?

DEEVERS: What do you guys want?

GABE: Justice!

JUSTIN: *(raising his eyebrows, laughing)* We're just curious about the sudden steep price increase on the pop machine.

MR. DEEVERS: Come on. Times are tough for education. We're depending on those proceeds to fund a lot.

JUSTIN: Fund more than just the band?

DEEVERS: *(fake smile)* Well, ha, ha, there will be an announcement tomorrow. Ha-ha.

GABE: **(Pg 20-21)** The next day I tried to hold it together by overdosing on the Dew. I robbed

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Grandpa of 20 bucks. Plucked four 5-dollar bills from his wallet while he fried eggs. Part of the reason my grandpa lives with us is because he's poor. He invested all his money in this power drink called *Tiger Lightning*. It supposedly had the essence of tiger testicles in it. But the secret ingredient was actually a steroid. *Tiger Lightning* was sued by the government. Grandpa lost just about everything.

I poured Code Red down my throat all morning. At lunch, I was sweating, probably on the edge of overdosing. I could barely talk. **(Pg 23)** *(bitterly, but with tremors)* Turns out that money wasn't even going to my band!

Justin, me and a few others sat at a table in the cafeteria just as Kailey Kaus and the rest of the cheerleaders streamed into the room to put up posters all over.

CHEERLEADERS: *[insert your favorite cheer here]*

GABE: **(Pg 25-26)** *(reading the poster)* YES, THE RUMORS ARE TRUE! THANK YOU FOR SUPPORTING THE NEW DANCE SQUAD WITH YOUR POP PURCHASE! All

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around they had drawn hearts and stars and smiley faces. It made me want to puke!

(Pg 24) I stared at Kailey Kaus. Let me admit this right now, sir: I used to love her. ***Used*** to. Back in elementary school we were more than best friends. We were like a little husband and wife. I was Luke Skywalker and she was Princess Leia. I had a toy light saber *(wields it for a moment, then enacts his memories)* We attacked the Death Star – ***We can do it!*** We raised her dolls together – *(in Kailey's voice)* ***Juniper has a runny nose, Luke, get a Kleenex!***

(embarrassed, the returns to the present) I hate her now. She is my enemy. **(Pg 25)** Those girls laugh behind my back. I'm Eight-Butt Johnson, man. I'm a fat, stupid joke to them.

(Pg 26) *(re-living his outrage)* This is fraud! We've been bamboozled! Kailey Kaus!

JUSTIN: Don't be so dramatic. Nobody's hiding anything. Just relax.

GABE: Bamboozled! **(Pg 33)** My hands were shaking by that point. *(calms himself)* **(Pg 32)** We all got to the

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band room and Mr. Shaver told us not to take our instruments out.

SHAVER: **(Pg 33)** *(takes a deep breath)* I'm very sorry to say there will be no marching camp this summer.

GABE: *(audible gasp)* **(Pg 95)** Band has been my life. Who would I even be? Nobody. My horn playing is the only claim to any kind of excellence I've got. I really don't do anything else. **(Pg 35)** *(his worst imaginings begin to build)* Maybe the marching band is losing its funding for next year . . . **(Pg 154)** Maybe the school's replaced band camp with this, this, this, stripper camp for cheerleaders! **(Pg 37)** This means war! *(launches his pretend light saber again)* **(Pg 130)** Why are you laughing?

(Pg 64) Firstly, all funding for marching camp comes from the pop machine. Secondly, Shaver wouldn't cancel it unless the money was gone. And thirdly, why cheerleaders? The same week the pop price goes up, the new dance squad is announced. **(Pg 96)** Who needs music at football games if there's a bunch of girls in skirts jumping around.

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(Pg 265) I'm getting our money back. I decided to redistribute all the money back to the people, just like Robin Hood, man! *(beat)* **(Pg 282)** [But] it was a terrible plan, sir – going to waltz into the school, take that money and leave without anyone knowing about it? **(Pg 270)** Then Kailey showed up. *(brief cut to Kailey flipping her hair)* **(Pg 271)** Was Kailey going to bring the whole Minnekota jock establishment down on my head? Was she setting up an ambush? *(breaths in deeply, then squeaks)* **(Pg 280)** Hi, there.

KAILEY: Gabe, I am the worst best friend you've ever had. I get pushed around by my mom. I get pushed around by [the cheerleaders] I'm so tired of all of these people, Gabe. I don't want to take your band away *(holding back tears)* I want to ***be*** in your band.

GABE: I really don't think she wants to be in the band, but that's pretty sweet of her to say. *(to Kailey, starstruck)* **(Pg 288)** You're pretty cool.

KAILEY: Not really. But now I'm with the leader of the rebellion. Gabe Skywalker, **(Pg 281-282)** I have a key and codes to the pop machine, we can use the force.

GABE: **(Pg 289)** *(hums Star Wars music)* We were Luke

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and Leia opening a security door in the Death Star. *(beat)* Of course, we're stupid. We didn't have a bag to put the money in. Luckily the change only contained quarters – 18 bucks. **(Pg 293)** The quarters jingled in my stretch pants pocket. **(Pg 292)** I took off. I ran! You can do this! I thought. **(Pg 130)** Why are you laughing?

OFF STAGE VOICE: **(Pg 293)** Gabe Johnston! Stop where you are! Stop running!

GABE: *(skids to a breathless stop one hand in the air, the other holding up his stretchy pants)* I stole the money! I stole the money!

OFFICER MCCOY: **(Pg 295)** *(on his shoulder radio mic)* Send a car. We got ourselves a little Spunk River ruckus going on. Gabe Johnson. Apprehended.

GABE: **(Pg 296)** [Turns out] McCoy was looking for me. Not because of the pop machine. Dad realized I was missing – didn't even try to find me himself – called the cops! They were all looking for me because of Dad.

(Pg 299) Yeah, I'm grounded. I got arrested for robbing a pop machine. That's a highly ground able

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business. **(Pg 306)** I had reporters grab me right away. They knew all about the Spunk River War. **(Pg 300)** Did you see the front page of the paper? "Fat Boy vs the Cheerleaders." Better laugh than cry in this case because fat boy is a sexy headline.

(Pg 306) *(softer and a bit sad)* I was tired of being called names and I'd learned how crappy it is to call people names in general. **(Pg 154)** *(echoing voice)* *"this, this, this, stripper camp for cheerleaders!"* Even if you think those people don't care, they care and it hurts and robs people of their dignity.

REPORTER: **(Pg 310-311)** Because of Gabriel Johnson's activism, the offending pop machine has been removed from the high school cafeteria. An increase in county property taxes will be on the ballot in the fall – to fund summer marching camp, a dance team, and most importantly, a healthy breakfast program for all schools.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Geoff Herbach
ISBN: 978-1402291418
Publisher: Sourcebooks Fire
Date (Month/Year): May 2014

AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

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